

Safety Helmet (Hard Hat) SOP

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1. Purpose

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) establishes the mandatory requirements for the selection, use, inspection, maintenance, and replacement of industrial safety helmets (hard hats) within all plant, warehouse, and construction areas. Head injuries caused by falling objects, swinging equipment, low overhead clearances, and accidental impact remain one of the leading causes of severe workplace injury. This procedure is designed to reduce that risk to as low as reasonably practicable by ensuring that every worker exposed to head-injury hazards wears an approved helmet correctly and consistently.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all employees, contractors, visitors, and third-party personnel entering designated helmet-mandatory zones, including production floors, warehouses, loading docks, construction sites, machine shops, and any area where overhead work, crane operations, or material handling is in progress. Helmet-mandatory zones are identified by blue mandatory signage at all entry points.

3. Responsibilities

- Site Safety Officer: Ensures adequate stock of approved helmets, verifies compliance during daily walkthroughs, and maintains inspection records.
- Department Supervisors: Confirm that every worker under their supervision wears a helmet before entering a mandatory zone and stop work if non-compliance is observed.
- Employees and Contractors: Wear the helmet correctly at all times within designated zones, report damage immediately, and never modify or paint the shell without manufacturer approval.
- Procurement Team: Sources helmets certified to IS 2925 / ANSI Z89.1 / EN 397 standards only.

4. Helmet Selection Criteria

Only helmets certified to recognized standards (IS 2925, ANSI Z89.1, or EN 397) may be issued. Type I helmets, which reduce impact from a blow to the top of the head, are standard issue for general plant use. Type II helmets, which also reduce lateral impact, are mandatory in areas with confined overhead structures or where lateral collision risk exists, such as near conveyor structures or scaffolding. Electrical-hazard rated (Class E) helmets must be used near live electrical equipment rated above 50V.

5. Correct Usage Procedure

- Inspect the shell for cracks, dents, discoloration, or brittleness before every shift.
- Check the suspension harness for frayed straps or loss of elasticity; the harness absorbs impact energy and a damaged harness must never be used.
- Adjust the headband so the helmet sits level, roughly 2.5 cm above the eyebrows, with the chin strap fastened when working at height or in windy conditions.

- Never wear a cap, hood, or other headwear underneath the helmet unless it is a manufacturer-approved liner.
- Store helmets away from direct sunlight, heat sources, and chemicals when not in use, as UV exposure degrades the shell material over time.

6. Inspection and Replacement

A documented visual inspection must be carried out before each use, and a formal monthly inspection must be logged by the Safety Officer using the PPE Inspection Register. Any helmet that has sustained a direct impact must be removed from service immediately and destroyed, even if no visible damage is present, because the internal suspension may have absorbed energy beyond its rated capacity. Helmets must be replaced every 3 years from the date of manufacture regardless of visible condition, and suspension harnesses replaced every 12 months.

7. Non-Compliance

Failure to wear an approved helmet in a mandatory zone will result in immediate removal from the work area, a documented safety violation, and mandatory refresher training. Repeated violations are escalated to the HR and EHS (Environment, Health and Safety) committee in line with the plant disciplinary policy.

8. Training and Records

All new employees and contractors must complete PPE induction training, including hands-on helmet fitting, before being granted access to mandatory zones. Training records are retained for the duration of employment plus five years in accordance with statutory recordkeeping requirements. Refresher training is conducted annually or after any incident involving head injury.